

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Project Management English



Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For project managers, program managers, PMO staff, scrum masters, delivery leads, operations managers, and cross-functional coordinators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Defining the deliverable

02 A critical dependency

03 Risk or issue?

04 A scope change

05 An honest status report

06 Resource negotiation

07 Handover to operations

08 Lessons learned

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Defining the deliverable

A sponsor and project manager clarify a vague request.

Roles: Project manager / Project sponsor

Project manager: When you say a customer portal, which capabilities must be in the first release?

Project sponsor: Order status and document downloads. Payments can wait.

Project manager: Who will accept the deliverable, and against what criteria?

Project sponsor: Operations will confirm that customers can find their orders and approved documents.

Project manager: Let's make those acceptance criteria measurable before we baseline the scope.

Project sponsor: Include our service manager in that discussion.

Project manager: I'll document the exclusions and send the scope statement for review.

Project sponsor: Good. That should also make later change requests easier to evaluate.

Notice the professional language

acceptance criteria - Specific conditions a deliverable must meet to be accepted.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A critical dependency

A project schedule depends on an external interface.

Roles: Project manager / Technical lead

Project manager: The interface specification is two weeks late. Does that move the critical path?

Technical lead: Yes. Integration testing depends on it, and there's no remaining float on that sequence.

Project manager: Can any work proceed independently?

Technical lead: We can build test fixtures against the draft, but rework remains possible.

Project manager: Give me that option with its assumptions and effort.

Technical lead: I'll also identify what the supplier must confirm before testing can start.

Project manager: I'll escalate the dependency to the sponsor.

Technical lead: Keep the current delivery date marked at risk until the schedule is reassessed.

Notice the professional language

critical path - Sequence of dependent work that determines the shortest feasible timeline.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Risk or issue?

A team reviews a late permit in its project register.

Roles: Project coordinator / Project manager

Project coordinator: The permit was due yesterday and hasn't arrived. Is it still just a risk?

Project manager: The missed milestone is now an issue. Further schedule impact is still uncertain.

Project coordinator: Should I close the original risk entry?

Project manager: Link it to the issue so we preserve the history and response plan.

Project coordinator: Who owns the follow-up?

Project manager: The permitting lead. Ask for the current status and expected decision window.

Project coordinator: I'll record the next review date and the affected activities.

Project manager: Good. Don't assign a revised completion date without checking those dependencies.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The permit was due yesterday and hasn't arrived. Is it still just a risk?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A scope change

A stakeholder requests a new dashboard during delivery.

Roles: Business owner / Project manager

Business owner: Can you add regional filters before launch? It sounds like a small change.

Project manager: It may be useful, but we need to assess data, testing, and schedule effects.

Business owner: Could we trade out the export feature?

Project manager: That's an option. The change request should compare both combinations.

Business owner: I can explain which business need is more urgent.

Project manager: I'll get an effort estimate and submit the options to the change authority.

Business owner: So it isn't included yet?

Project manager: Correct. We'll update the approved scope and plan after the decision.

Notice the professional language

change request - A proposal to alter an agreed product, scope, schedule, or process.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

An honest status report

A sponsor questions a green status indicator.

Roles: Sponsor / Project manager

Sponsor: Why is the project green when user testing hasn't started?

Project manager: You're right to question it. The report didn't reflect the new test-data delay.

Sponsor: What does that mean for the milestone?

Project manager: It's at risk. We haven't quantified the full effect yet.

Sponsor: Then tell the steering group what decision you need.

Project manager: I'll show the dependency, two recovery options, and the date we need an answer.

Sponsor: Make the reporting period explicit too.

Project manager: I'll correct the status and circulate the revised report before the meeting.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Why is the project green when user testing hasn't started?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Resource negotiation

Two project managers need the same specialist.

Roles: Project manager / Resource manager

Project manager: I need the security architect for five days next week.

Resource manager: She's already allocated to an incident review. Which tasks truly require her?

Project manager: The threat-model review and design signoff. Documentation could be prepared by our analyst.

Resource manager: Could two focused review sessions cover the immediate need?

Project manager: Possibly, if the analyst completes the evidence pack first.

Resource manager: I'll ask the architect to assess that plan before changing her allocation.

Project manager: I'll send the decisions and preparation required for each session.

Resource manager: Then we can confirm a feasible commitment and flag any remaining gap.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "She's already allocated to an incident review. Which tasks truly require her?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Handover to operations

The delivery team prepares to transfer a service.

Roles: Delivery manager / Operations lead

Delivery manager: The build is complete. Are you ready to accept the service?

Operations lead: Not yet. The runbook lacks escalation contacts, and support training is incomplete.

Delivery manager: Let's distinguish technical completion from operational acceptance.

Operations lead: Exactly. We also need the outstanding defect list and monitoring arrangements.

Delivery manager: I'll assign owners and dates to those handover items.

Operations lead: I'll review the completed evidence against our acceptance checklist.

Delivery manager: Can we schedule the acceptance meeting provisionally?

Operations lead: Yes, provided the invitation makes clear that approval is still pending.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The build is complete. Are you ready to accept the service?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Lessons learned

A project team reviews a missed milestone.

Roles: Project manager / Workstream lead

Project manager: What contributed to the missed milestone beyond the supplier delay?

Workstream lead: We didn't verify the dependency early enough, and the escalation route was unclear.

Project manager: What change would help the next project?

Workstream lead: A dependency review at kickoff with named owners and trigger dates.

Project manager: Who can put that into the standard planning checklist?

Workstream lead: The delivery office. I'll draft the addition for its review.

Project manager: Let's record the action and a check that it was adopted.

Workstream lead: Agreed. A lesson isn't useful if it stays only in these minutes.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What contributed to the missed milestone beyond the supplier delay?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Project Charter and Scope Definition

SHARED CASE

A sponsor requests a dashboard but the brief does not define users, decisions, or excluded features.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Who will use the dashboard, and what decision should it support? Let's agree on those needs and the exclusions before we estimate the work or call the scope complete.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Schedule, Critical Path, and Dependencies

SHARED CASE

A testing task is three days late and blocks the release rehearsal. Other work is on schedule.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

Testing is three days late and is blocking the release rehearsal. Other tasks remain on schedule. I'll show the dependency and the proposed recovery options in the schedule update.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Risk Register and Issue Escalation

SHARED CASE

A risk register still lists a supplier delay as a possibility, although the supplier has confirmed it will miss the delivery date.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The delay is now a confirmed issue, not only a future risk. I'll update its status and ask the responsible owner to document the impact and next action.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Stakeholder Alignment and Governance

SHARED CASE

A project meeting ends with several recommendations but no indication of who approves the change.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

We have a recommendation, but approval is still outstanding. Who has authority to approve this change, and what information do they need? I'll record the decision route in the meeting notes.

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Change Requests and Scope Creep

SHARED CASE

A sponsor asks for a new report two weeks before launch. The team can add it only by moving another feature or extending the schedule.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Cover this until after your first attempt

We can assess the new report as a scope change. To include it, we would need to move another feature or extend the schedule. Which tradeoff should we develop for review?

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Status Reporting and Executive Updates

SHARED CASE

A project is labeled green despite an unresolved dependency that threatens its planned date. The reporting criteria require material threats to be visible.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

The current label does not show the unresolved dependency. I'll report the delivery threat, its impact, and the decision needed so the status reflects the agreed criteria.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Vendor and Cross-Functional Delivery

SHARED CASE

A vendor says a deliverable is complete, but the team cannot find evidence for two acceptance criteria.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you provide the evidence for these two criteria or identify any outstanding work? We need to review the deliverable against the agreed criteria before confirming acceptance.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Post-Implementation Review

SHARED CASE

A project review repeatedly says "communication was poor." The team has no concrete improvement action.

Role A | Responding professional

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Useful expressions

In [specific situation], I noticed ...

The effect was ... What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Which message or handoff caused difficulty, and what happened as a result? Let's turn that example into a specific change, assign an owner, and decide how we will check whether it helped.

Second round

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Who will use the warehouse dashboard?

Fictional charter discussion: a sponsor has requested a warehouse dashboard without defining its users or boundaries.

01 • Project manager: Before we draft the charter, which people will use this dashboard to make decisions?

02 • Operations sponsor: Shift supervisors need to decide where to assign staff when packing queues grow.

03 • Project manager: Does the scope include assigning staff automatically, or only showing the queue information?

04 • Operations sponsor: Only showing information. Supervisors should still make the assignment decisions themselves.

05 • Project manager: Then automatic scheduling is an exclusion. What refresh interval would support those decisions?

06 • Operations sponsor: I assumed live updates, but I haven't checked what the warehouse system provides.

07 • Project manager: Let's keep live updates as an assumption to investigate, not a confirmed requirement.

08 • Operations sponsor: Agreed. Can the charter distinguish that question from the agreed supervisor audience?

09 • Project manager: Yes. I'll confirm the audience and boundary, with refresh timing explicitly unresolved.

10 • Operations sponsor: I'll introduce you to the system owner so we can clarify that dependency.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Moving records without cleaning every record

Fictional archive project: a coordinator and sponsor define a migration involving 4,000 historical records.

01 • Project coordinator: Our draft scope covers moving 4,000 records. Does migration also mean correcting their contents?

02 • Archive sponsor: I expected duplicate records to disappear, but I haven't specified how to identify them.

03 • Project coordinator: Matching titles alone could merge different records. Who can define the duplicate criteria?

04 • Archive sponsor: The records lead can advise, although her review time hasn't been allocated yet.

05 • Project coordinator: Then I suggest separating transfer from cleanup in the charter until that review happens.

06 • Archive sponsor: Would cleanup become an exclusion, or would we lose the option completely?

07 • Project coordinator: An exclusion from this initial scope, not a permanent ban on a later project.

08 • Archive sponsor: That distinction helps. Please avoid describing all transferred records as verified or corrected.

09 • Project coordinator: I'll say the transfer preserves existing contents, subject to agreed transfer checks.

10 • Archive sponsor: Good. I'll ask the records lead to clarify the cleanup requirement before approval.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A pilot is not a regional rollout

Fictional booking-system kickoff: the brief names one training center, while a stakeholder expects three centers.

01 • Project manager: The brief names East Center. Are we authorizing a pilot there or a three-center rollout?

02 • Training director: I mentioned three centers in conversation, but the funding request covers only East Center.

03 • Project manager: Thanks. Should our charter describe the other centers as possible later phases?

04 • Training director: Yes, provided that does not imply their funding or start dates are approved.

05 • Project manager: Understood. Which outcome would show whether the pilot deserves a later expansion discussion?

06 • Training director: We need evidence that staff can complete bookings without maintaining a second reservation list.

07 • Project manager: Is eliminating that list a requirement, or an assumption about how staff will work?

08 • Training director: A desired outcome. We still need to check their reconciliation needs before finalizing it.

09 • Project manager: I'll record that open question and keep the additional centers outside the initial scope.

10 • Training director: That gives us a clear boundary without pretending the future decision has been made.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Project Charter and Scope Definition

A sponsor requests a dashboard but the brief does not define users, decisions, or excluded features.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Who will use the dashboard, and what decision should it support? Let's agree on those needs and the exclusions before we estimate the work or call the scope complete.

Scenario 2 | Does training include contractors?

In a fictional equipment-tracking project, the charter includes training 12 employees. A coordinator asks whether six contractors are included. Their access needs and available training time are unknown. Agree what must be clarified before extending the scope.

Role A: Project manager: explain the current boundary and ask about the contractor use case.

Role B: Facilities coordinator: request contractor training without assuming access or additional funding is approved.

Possible opening: The charter covers 12 employees; could you clarify what the six contractors need to do?

Success checks

- Distinguish the agreed audience from the requested addition.
- Identify access and training-time assumptions.
- Agree who will clarify the requirement before a commitment.

Add a complication: The coordinator calls contractor training a minor detail that should not affect scope.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Testing blocks the rehearsal

Fictional release update using the lesson case: testing is three days late and blocks the release rehearsal; other work is on schedule.

01 • Project manager: Testing is three days late, and the release rehearsal cannot begin until it finishes.

02 • Sponsor: The training materials are complete. Doesn't that mean the overall milestone is still secure?

03 • Project manager: Those materials are useful, but they do not remove the rehearsal's dependency on testing.

04 • Sponsor: Are you saying the release must now move by exactly three days as well?

05 • Project manager: Not yet. We need the remaining sequence and available buffer before calculating that effect.

06 • Sponsor: Please separate confirmed delay from your forecast so I can explain the situation accurately.

07 • Project manager: Confirmed: testing is late and rehearsal is blocked. The final milestone impact remains under review.

08 • Sponsor: Who will check whether recovery options change the critical path rather than just add activity?

09 • Project manager: I'll review the sequence with the test lead and bring a revised forecast.

10 • Sponsor: Good. Keep the completed materials visible, but don't let them conceal the blocking task.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

The furniture delivery has spare time

Fictional office project: furniture delivery slips two days; its schedule has four days of buffer, while network approval remains pending.

01 • Facilities lead: Furniture is arriving two days later. Should we announce that the opening milestone has slipped?

02 • Scheduler: That delivery had four days of buffer, so this change alone does not move the opening.

03 • Facilities lead: Then can we say the schedule is safe because two buffer days remain?

04 • Scheduler: Only for that activity. Network approval is still pending and needs its own dependency review.

05 • Facilities lead: I see. A visible delay isn't necessarily the task controlling our completion date.

06 • Scheduler: Exactly. The critical path follows the linked work that determines the milestone in this schedule.

07 • Facilities lead: Should I ask the furniture supplier to pay for faster transport anyway?

08 • Scheduler: First check whether earlier delivery would change the opening forecast or simply restore buffer.

09 • Facilities lead: I'll report the delivery change separately and ask the network owner for an approval update.

10 • Scheduler: I'll update the schedule logic and flag any change to the opening forecast.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Overlapping work needs a checked dependency

Fictional museum installation: label proofreading is complete, but printing depends on curator approval that has not arrived.

01 • Exhibition manager: Proofreading is complete. Can printing start while we wait for the curator's approval?

02 • Production coordinator: The current schedule makes approval a predecessor because the curator can still change captions.

03 • Exhibition manager: Could we overlap the tasks to protect Friday's installation milestone without changing that dependency?

04 • Production coordinator: Overlapping them would change our plan and create a risk of printing obsolete captions.

05 • Exhibition manager: What work can proceed now without assuming approval or consuming the print budget twice?

06 • Production coordinator: We can prepare print files, but the release to the printer should remain pending.

07 • Exhibition manager: Does preparation shorten the remaining duration enough to preserve the milestone?

08 • Production coordinator: I need the printer's confirmed turnaround before answering. Our existing estimate is not a commitment.

09 • Exhibition manager: Please check that turnaround. Show proofreading complete, file preparation pending, approval pending, and printing not started.

10 • Production coordinator: I'll return with the dependency update and a conditional forecast, not an unsupported promise.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Schedule, Critical Path, and Dependencies

A testing task is three days late and blocks the release rehearsal. Other work is on schedule.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: Testing is three days late and is blocking the release rehearsal. Other tasks remain on schedule. I'll show the dependency and the proposed recovery options in the schedule update.

Scenario 2 | One interpreter, two milestones

A fictional project has two workshops on Thursday, both requiring the same interpreter. Each workshop is ready otherwise. The interpreter's availability has not been confirmed. Explain the shared dependency and agree the next scheduling check.

Role A: Scheduler: distinguish workshop preparation from resource confirmation.

Role B: Workshop lead: ask whether moving one workshop would solve the conflict without assuming availability.

Possible opening: Both workshops are prepared, but they still depend on the same unconfirmed interpreter.

Success checks

- Name the shared resource dependency.
- Keep preparation separate from delivery readiness.
- Agree to confirm availability before promising replacement times.

Add a complication: A sponsor asks you to mark both milestones complete because the slides are finished.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A possible delay becomes an issue

Fictional supplier review using the lesson case: the supplier has confirmed it will miss delivery, but the risk register still says possible delay.

01 • Project analyst: The supplier confirmed a missed delivery date, but our risk register still calls it possible.

02 • Project manager: Then the delay is an issue now. Do we have a confirmed replacement delivery date?

03 • Project analyst: No. Their message confirms the miss but says the revised date is still being assessed.

04 • Project manager: Please create an issue-log entry without turning that unknown date into a planning fact.

05 • Project analyst: Should the original risk entry disappear once the issue has an owner?

06 • Project manager: Keep its history and link it to the issue so we can trace the escalation.

07 • Project analyst: We discussed another supplier earlier. Can I list that as a completed mitigation?

08 • Project manager: No. A discussion is not secured supply. Record it as an option needing assessment.

09 • Project analyst: I'll distinguish the confirmed miss, unknown replacement date, and proposed alternative in today's update.

10 • Project manager: Assign me as owner for coordinating the impact assessment and requesting the revised date.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

The permit rumor needs evidence

Fictional venue project: a coordinator hears an unconfirmed rumor that a permit was rejected; the authority has issued no decision.

01 • Venue coordinator: A colleague heard our permit was rejected. Should I escalate a confirmed project blockage?

02 • Project manager: What evidence do we have beyond that conversation? Has the issuing office sent a decision?

03 • Venue coordinator: No decision has arrived. The application tracker still shows that review is in progress.

04 • Project manager: Then rejection is unconfirmed. We can flag uncertainty without reporting a rejection as fact.

05 • Venue coordinator: Would that belong in the risk register rather than the issue log for rejected permits?

06 • Project manager: Yes, describe the possible schedule effect and identify who will verify the application's status.

07 • Venue coordinator: Could reserving an alternative venue be our mitigation, even though it might incur charges?

08 • Project manager: List it as a proposed option requiring cost and approval checks, not an authorized booking.

09 • Venue coordinator: I'll contact the application owner and retain the tracker status as our current evidence.

10 • Project manager: Good. Escalate any confirmed change promptly, with the evidence and affected milestone clearly stated.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A backup exists but has not been tested

Fictional training launch: a risk register says backup laptops mitigate equipment shortages, but the eight stored laptops have not been checked.

01 • Delivery lead: Our equipment risk is marked resolved because eight backup laptops are in storage.

02 • Risk coordinator: Have those laptops been tested with the training application, or have we only counted them?

03 • Delivery lead: Only counted. The storage inventory confirms eight devices, not whether their software is ready.

04 • Risk coordinator: Then their existence is an observation; their readiness is still an assumption behind the mitigation.

05 • Delivery lead: Would reopening the risk imply that every backup laptop is faulty?

06 • Risk coordinator: No. It means the mitigation is unverified, not that failure has been established.

07 • Delivery lead: I'll ask the support lead to own the readiness check. What evidence should we request?

08 • Risk coordinator: Request the check results and any unresolved access requirements for each device, using the project checklist.

09 • Delivery lead: Until those results arrive, I'll report the backup count and the outstanding validation separately.

10 • Risk coordinator: That is clear. We can reassess the remaining risk once the owner confirms actual readiness.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Risk Register and Issue Escalation

A risk register still lists a supplier delay as a possibility, although the supplier has confirmed it will miss the delivery date.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The delay is now a confirmed issue, not only a future risk. I'll update its status and ask the responsible owner to document the impact and next action.

Scenario 2 | An unavailable reviewer

In a fictional translation project, the sole reviewer confirms she cannot work next week. The review milestone is next Wednesday. A substitute has been suggested but has not accepted. Discuss the issue, possible mitigation, and escalation owner.

Role A: Project coordinator: report the confirmed absence and unresolved coverage.

Role B: Delivery manager: challenge any claim that the substitute has solved the problem.

Possible opening: The reviewer's absence is confirmed; replacement coverage is still only a proposal.

Success checks

- Separate absence evidence from coverage assumptions.
- Identify an owner and the affected milestone.
- Keep the issue open until replacement readiness is assessed.

Add a complication: Someone wants the issue closed after an invitation is sent to the substitute.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Recommendations without an approver

Fictional governance meeting using the lesson case: participants have recommended a change, but approval authority is unclear.

01 • Project manager: We have several recommendations, but who has decision rights for approving this particular change?

02 • Operations lead: I assumed the people in this meeting could approve it because we all supported discussion.

03 • Project manager: Participation doesn't establish approval authority. Can we check the governance arrangements before recording a decision?

04 • Operations lead: The RACI may help, although I don't have the current version in front of me.

05 • Project manager: Let's confirm that document rather than guessing who is accountable for this change category.

06 • Operations lead: Should we send the recommendation straight to the steering committee while we check?

07 • Project manager: We can prepare it, but first invite the delivery team to describe the implementation impact.

08 • Operations lead: They haven't spoken yet. I'll ask them to identify the resource question that remains open.

09 • Project manager: I'll record a recommendation awaiting the confirmed approver, not a change already authorized.

10 • Operations lead: Agreed. We'll close with the open authority question and an owner for resolving it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Consulted does not mean accountable

Fictional training project: the agreed RACI names the training director as approver and the IT lead as consulted on platform changes.

01 • IT lead: I reviewed the proposed platform change. Why does the meeting note call me the final approver?

02 • Project coordinator: I confused your technical review with approval. Our RACI lists you as consulted, not accountable.

03 • IT lead: Correct. The training director approves, but she needs my compatibility concerns before deciding.

04 • Project coordinator: Could you explain the unresolved concern now so the recommendation includes your actual position?

05 • IT lead: We haven't checked whether existing course links will still work after the change.

06 • Project coordinator: Then your review is not an unconditional endorsement. I'll make that distinction explicit.

07 • IT lead: Please also invite the course administrator, who understands how those links are used daily.

08 • Project coordinator: I'll include that perspective and ask the director whether she needs verification before deciding.

09 • IT lead: Can you confirm that no implementation instruction will be sent on my behalf meanwhile?

10 • Project coordinator: Yes. I'll correct the note and retain the change as awaiting the director's decision.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The absent service desk needs a voice

Fictional steering discussion: leaders favor weekend deployment, but the service desk has not been consulted and support coverage is unknown.

01 • Steering chair: Most participants prefer weekend deployment. Can we close this item as agreed and move on?

02 • Project manager: Before that, the service desk hasn't contributed, and weekend support coverage remains an open question.

03 • Steering chair: Their representative is absent. Does that mean we must abandon today's discussion completely?

04 • Project manager: No. We can record the preference and request their input before you make the final decision.

05 • Steering chair: What specifically should they clarify rather than giving us another general opinion about timing?

06 • Project manager: Whether they can cover the proposed window and what escalation arrangements would be needed.

07 • Steering chair: I hold the decision rights here, but I don't want silence treated as their agreement.

08 • Project manager: I'll mark their view as pending and summarize the operational question for their response.

09 • Steering chair: Please bring back the recommendation once their coverage position is known, including any unresolved gap.

10 • Project manager: Understood. Today's outcome is a preferred option, not authorization to deploy that weekend.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Stakeholder Alignment and Governance

A project meeting ends with several recommendations but no indication of who approves the change.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: We have a recommendation, but approval is still outstanding. Who has authority to approve this change, and what information do they need? I'll record the decision route in the meeting notes.

Scenario 2 | Who can accept the pilot?

A fictional pilot has finished. The sponsor approves funding, the operations lead receives the service, and the charter does not name the acceptance decision-maker. Facilitate a short discussion to resolve authority before declaring acceptance.

Role A: Project manager: invite operational concerns and identify the missing decision right.

Role B: Operations lead: ask whether receiving the service gives you formal acceptance authority.

Possible opening: Delivery is finished, but the charter does not tell us who can formally accept the pilot.

Success checks

- Separate funding authority from acceptance authority.
- Invite the receiving team's perspective.
- Agree who will clarify governance before recording acceptance.

Add a complication: The sponsor's assistant says funding approval should count as acceptance.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A late report needs a tradeoff

Fictional launch negotiation using the lesson case: a new report is requested two weeks before launch; it requires moving another feature or extending the schedule.

01 • Sponsor: Can you add the new report before launch in two weeks? It would help our review.

02 • Project manager: We can assess that change request, but the team cannot add it within the unchanged baseline.

03 • Sponsor: What choices would let us include the report without simply asking everyone to work longer?

04 • Project manager: We could move another feature out of this release or propose a later launch date.

05 • Sponsor: I'd rather move a feature. Can you choose something small and tell the team immediately?

06 • Project manager: First we need impact analysis and confirmation that the displaced feature's stakeholders accept that proposal.

07 • Sponsor: Then show me the affected work and the decisions required, not just a revised feature list.

08 • Project manager: Agreed. Until approval, the existing scope and schedule remain our baseline for reporting.

09 • Sponsor: I'll review the options and speak with the stakeholder whose feature might move.

10 • Project manager: I'll bring the tradeoffs for that discussion without treating today's request as authorization.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Five small additions make real work

Fictional portal project: five separate wording and layout requests arrived after scope approval; their combined effort has not been assessed.

01 • Customer representative: These are only five small improvements. Can the designers absorb them without a formal change discussion?

02 • Project manager: Perhaps some are small individually, but we haven't assessed their combined effort or testing impact.

03 • Customer representative: I don't want paperwork to delay fixing labels that users genuinely find confusing.

04 • Project manager: Neither do I. Let's review them together and distinguish essential corrections from new behavior.

05 • Customer representative: One request adds a filter, while the other four change text or positioning.

06 • Project manager: That filter may affect scope differently. Could we prioritize the requests before estimating a package?

07 • Customer representative: Yes. The unclear labels come first; the filter could wait if it threatens delivery.

08 • Project manager: I'll arrange the assessment against our baseline and bring a proposed split for approval.

09 • Customer representative: Please don't promise all five simply because I called them small at the start.

10 • Project manager: Understood. We'll avoid scope creep by making the accepted work and deferred work explicit.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Replacing a workshop with recordings

Fictional onboarding project: the approved scope includes two live workshops; a sponsor requests ten edited recordings instead.

01 • Sponsor: Could we replace the two live workshops with ten recordings and keep the same delivery date?

02 • Project manager: That changes the deliverables, not just the format. Editing and review effort need an impact analysis.

03 • Sponsor: But removing live delivery should free time. Why wouldn't the effort simply balance out?

04 • Project manager: It may free facilitator time, but recording production uses different work and possibly different people.

05 • Sponsor: Could we start with two unedited demonstrations while you assess the full recording proposal?

06 • Project manager: We can examine that option, provided we clarify quality expectations and who must approve them.

07 • Sponsor: I can explain the intended audience, but I cannot authorize production resources from another department.

08 • Project manager: Then I'll take the alternative to that resource owner before revising the project baseline.

09 • Sponsor: Please keep the original workshops in place until the replacement is actually approved.

10 • Project manager: Agreed. We'll compare the options and confirm the replacement decision rather than silently changing scope.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Change Requests and Scope Creep

A sponsor asks for a new report two weeks before launch. The team can add it only by moving another feature or extending the schedule.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: We can assess the new report as a scope change. To include it, we would need to move another feature or extend the schedule. Which tradeoff should we develop for review?

Scenario 2 | A second language at the last review

A fictional visitor guide is approved in English. A stakeholder now requests a Spanish version. Translation and review estimates are unavailable, and the printing slot is fixed for next week. Negotiate an assessment route without promising delivery.

Role A: Project manager: explain which scope and schedule questions need review.

Role B: Visitor-services lead: explain why the additional language matters and consider phased delivery.

Possible opening: We can assess a Spanish version, but we do not yet know whether reviewed translation fits next week's printing slot.

Success checks

- Treat the addition as a change request.
- Offer a conditional phased option without inventing estimates.
- Identify the review and approval needed before changing the baseline.

Add a complication: The stakeholder offers to skip language review to preserve the date.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Green conceals the unresolved dependency

Fictional status review using the lesson case: an unresolved dependency threatens the date, and project reporting criteria require material threats to be visible.

01 • Reporting analyst: The project is still green, although the unresolved dependency threatens the planned completion date.

02 • Project manager: Then the report isn't showing the material threat required by our reporting criteria.

03 • Reporting analyst: Most tasks are complete. Could I keep the green RAG status and mention the dependency below?

04 • Project manager: Task completion alone doesn't establish schedule confidence. Apply the agreed criteria to the threat itself.

05 • Reporting analyst: Should I state that the date has already slipped, or would that overstate the evidence?

06 • Project manager: It would overstate it. Say the date is threatened and explain which dependency remains unresolved.

07 • Reporting analyst: What decision ask would make this useful for the executive meeting rather than merely alarming?

08 • Project manager: Ask the dependency owner to confirm their delivery position so we can assess the forecast.

09 • Reporting analyst: I'll separate completed tasks, pending input, and the unconfirmed effect on the date.

10 • Project manager: Good. Show the reason for the status and avoid assigning a color without context.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Scanned is not accepted

Fictional digitization project: 80 of 100 batches are scanned, but 12 scanned batches await quality review and acceptance totals are unknown.

01 • Executive sponsor: Eighty batches scanned sounds like eighty percent delivered. Can I use that in tomorrow's update?

02 • Project manager: You can say eighty percent scanned, but accepted delivery is a different measure in this project.

03 • Executive sponsor: What remains between scanning and acceptance that changes the interpretation of that progress figure?

04 • Project manager: Twelve scanned batches await quality review. We haven't confirmed the overall accepted-batch count yet.

05 • Executive sponsor: The scanned count does not establish the accepted count. Have I understood that distinction correctly?

06 • Project manager: Correct. Our status report should show scanning and acceptance separately, with pending quality reviews visible.

07 • Executive sponsor: Please keep the update brief. What can you state now without waiting for every detail?

08 • Project manager: Eighty batches are scanned; twelve await review; the verified acceptance total is being reconciled.

09 • Executive sponsor: That's clear. Ask the quality owner to supply the acceptance count before we claim delivery progress.

10 • Project manager: I'll do that and label any incomplete figure instead of presenting it as verified.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An executive update with a real ask

Fictional records project: the migration rehearsal passed, but the records owner has not selected which archive to retire.

01 • Project manager: The migration rehearsal passed. Retirement planning is pending because the records owner hasn't selected the archive.

02 • Portfolio director: Your status report lists that as a concern, but what exactly do you need from me?

03 • Project manager: Please help secure a decision meeting with the records owner; I cannot choose their retention approach.

04 • Portfolio director: Does this mean the technical migration has failed, or only that the business decision remains open?

05 • Project manager: The rehearsal passed under its test conditions. The open decision blocks planning the archive retirement.

06 • Portfolio director: Can you explain that distinction in one sentence during the executive update?

07 • Project manager: Technical rehearsal is complete, but retirement planning awaits the records owner's choice of archive.

08 • Portfolio director: Good. Include the options they must consider, without recommending deletion before their review.

09 • Project manager: I'll state the decision ask and the pending dependency alongside the completed rehearsal.

10 • Portfolio director: I'll arrange the discussion and confirm who needs to attend before we set expectations.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Status Reporting and Executive Updates

A project is labeled green despite an unresolved dependency that threatens its planned date. The reporting criteria require material threats to be visible.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: The current label does not show the unresolved dependency. I'll report the delivery threat, its impact, and the decision needed so the status reflects the agreed criteria.

Scenario 2 | A status date that is already old

A fictional executive report uses a staffing forecast prepared ten days ago. Two transfers have since been proposed but not confirmed. The dashboard refreshed this morning. Give an accurate verbal update on what is current and what is pending.

Role A: Reporting lead: explain the age and limits of the forecast.

Role B: Executive sponsor: ask whether today's dashboard refresh means staffing is confirmed.

Possible opening: The dashboard refreshed today, but its staffing forecast is ten days old and needs review.

Success checks

- Distinguish report refresh from forecast verification.
- Keep proposed staffing separate from confirmed staffing.
- End with a clear request for an updated owner-confirmed forecast.

Add a complication: The meeting chair asks you to describe the proposed transfers as secured resources.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Complete without acceptance evidence

Fictional vendor review using the lesson case: the vendor calls a deliverable complete, but evidence for two acceptance criteria cannot be found.

01 • Delivery manager: You marked the deliverable complete, but we cannot find evidence for two acceptance criteria.

02 • Vendor lead: Do you mean those checks failed, or that the results are missing from the handoff?

03 • Delivery manager: The results are missing. We aren't claiming failure; we need the evidence to assess acceptance.

04 • Vendor lead: Could you identify the criteria precisely so I can ask the right people for results?

05 • Delivery manager: I'll point to the two unlinked entries in the agreed acceptance checklist during our review.

06 • Vendor lead: Is tomorrow afternoon acceptable for checking whether those results exist and reporting any gaps?

07 • Delivery manager: Yes. Please provide the evidence or an explicit gap update then, rather than another completion label.

08 • Vendor lead: Should we discuss escalation now, or wait until we know what remains unresolved?

09 • Delivery manager: Let's first use that agreed checkpoint, then follow the project's escalation route for unresolved gaps.

10 • Vendor lead: Understood. I'll confirm receipt of the checklist and return with a criterion-by-criterion response.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Response time is not restoration time

Fictional support handoff: a draft summary confuses an acknowledged support ticket with restoration of the affected service; SLA wording has not been checked.

01 • Project coordinator: The vendor acknowledged our ticket within an hour. Can I mark the service issue resolved?

02 • Service manager: Acknowledgment confirms a response, not restoration. Do we have evidence the service works again?

03 • Project coordinator: Not yet. I also wrote that the vendor met the SLA, based on that response.

04 • Service manager: Please check which service-level agreement measure applies before making that claim about overall performance.

05 • Project coordinator: Could you send the relevant agreement section and identify who confirms service restoration?

06 • Service manager: I'll locate the section. The support team can report the service condition, but verification is pending.

07 • Project coordinator: Can we review both items at our scheduled afternoon handoff so the status is accurate?

08 • Service manager: Yes. Keep the acknowledgment time visible and label restoration as unconfirmed in the meantime.

09 • Project coordinator: I'll request a restoration update with supporting checks, not simply ask whether the ticket is closed.

10 • Service manager: That will give the receiving team a clear basis for deciding the next action.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Training files that the receiving team cannot open

Fictional vendor delivery: training videos were uploaded, but the customer training team reports access denied; no content review has occurred.

01 • Training manager: The video links return access denied, so our team hasn't been able to review the deliverable.

02 • Vendor coordinator: The upload completed yesterday. Does your message mean the videos themselves are unacceptable?

03 • Training manager: No. We haven't viewed them. Please arrange access for the named reviewers so assessment can begin.

04 • Vendor coordinator: Would making the folder public be the quickest way to solve the access problem?

05 • Training manager: We need the agreed restricted sharing arrangement, not public access to unpublished training materials.

06 • Vendor coordinator: Understood. Can you confirm the reviewer list through the project channel while I check permissions?

07 • Training manager: Yes. Please give us an access update before tomorrow's review session, or flag any delay earlier.

08 • Vendor coordinator: Once access works, will you confirm acceptance immediately so I can close our delivery task?

09 • Training manager: We'll confirm receipt first. Acceptance follows review against the agreed content and accessibility criteria.

10 • Vendor coordinator: I'll distinguish upload, accessible handoff, and acceptance in the delivery tracker from now on.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Vendor and Cross-Functional Delivery

A vendor says a deliverable is complete, but the team cannot find evidence for two acceptance criteria.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could you provide the evidence for these two criteria or identify any outstanding work? We need to review the deliverable against the agreed criteria before confirming acceptance.

Scenario 2 | A missing source-file handoff

A fictional vendor has supplied a final poster PDF, but the agreed deliverable also includes editable source files. Those files are missing. A campaign review is scheduled tomorrow afternoon. Make a specific request and agree a realistic checkpoint.

Role A: Campaign project manager: request the missing files for the receiving design team's use.

Role B: Vendor coordinator: confirm the gap and offer a progress update without promising files you have not located.

Possible opening: We received the PDF, but the editable source files in the acceptance checklist are still missing.

Success checks

- Name the missing deliverable and its purpose.
- Distinguish receipt from complete acceptance.
- Agree a timed update and route for any remaining gap.

Add a complication: The vendor offers a screenshot as a substitute for an editable file.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Replace poor communication with an observable event

Fictional post-implementation review: the team has described communication as poor; a coordinator can identify a specific unshared schedule change.

01 • Review facilitator: Our postmortem keeps saying communication was poor. Which observed event should we actually examine?

02 • Project coordinator: The rehearsal moved from Tuesday to Thursday, but the service desk received only the original invitation.

03 • Review facilitator: What effect did that have, and how do we know rather than assume?

04 • Project coordinator: Their lead reported preparing coverage for Tuesday and missing Thursday's rehearsal because the invitation was unchanged.

05 • Review facilitator: That's a useful behavioral example. Does it establish the root cause of every communication problem?

06 • Project coordinator: No. It identifies one handoff failure that we can address without generalizing about everyone.

07 • Review facilitator: What action item would change that handoff and let us check whether it improves?

08 • Project coordinator: Assign the schedule owner to update invitations and request acknowledgment from affected teams after date changes.

09 • Review facilitator: Let's confirm an owner and test that action during the next scheduled change.

10 • Project coordinator: I'll take ownership of the trial and bring the acknowledgment results to our follow-up.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

The checklist was present but unused

Fictional review: a launch checklist existed, but the handoff meeting ended without reviewing its open access item.

01 • Project sponsor: Our lesson learned should be to create a checklist so access gaps stop happening.

02 • Delivery lead: We already had a checklist. The handoff meeting ended without discussing its open access item.

03 • Project sponsor: Thanks for correcting that. So the observed problem was how we used it, not its absence.

04 • Delivery lead: Exactly. The receiving team discovered the unresolved access question after the handoff and could not start.

05 • Project sponsor: Would requiring more checklist fields address the root cause, or are we jumping ahead?

06 • Delivery lead: We would be jumping ahead. First ask why the open item was skipped during the meeting.

07 • Project sponsor: For the next handoff, could we explicitly discuss unresolved items before confirming readiness?

08 • Delivery lead: Yes. I'll lead that review and ask the receiving lead to repeat any remaining constraints.

09 • Project sponsor: Let's evaluate whether that changes the handoff, rather than declaring the issue solved today.

10 • Delivery lead: Agreed. The action item will include an owner and a follow-up on receiving-team feedback.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A successful trial still needs a bounded lesson

Fictional review: one pilot team used a ten-minute daily dependency check and reported fewer missed handoffs; no comparison group was used.

01 • Project analyst: The pilot reported fewer missed handoffs after adding a ten-minute daily dependency check.

02 • Review facilitator: That's encouraging. Are we ready to say the meeting caused the improvement across every team?

03 • Project analyst: No. We have one team's report and no comparison group, so other changes could matter.

04 • Review facilitator: How can we preserve the useful lesson learned without presenting a universal rule?

05 • Project analyst: Describe what the team did, the reported effect, and the limits of the evidence.

06 • Review facilitator: What next action would test whether another team benefits without imposing another permanent meeting?

07 • Project analyst: Invite a second team to a short trial and ask them to track missed handoffs consistently.

08 • Review facilitator: Who will collect that feedback and check whether the added meeting creates unnecessary work?

09 • Project analyst: I'll coordinate with the second team's lead and include time cost in the review.

10 • Review facilitator: Good. Our postmortem will recommend a bounded trial, not mandate a meeting based on one experience.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Post-Implementation Review

A project review repeatedly says "communication was poor." The team has no concrete improvement action.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Second round: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Model for scenario 1: Which message or handoff caused difficulty, and what happened as a result? Let's turn that example into a specific change, assign an owner, and decide how we will check whether it helped.

Scenario 2 | The useful escalation came too late

In a fictional project, a resource conflict was raised two days before a workshop although it had been noticed a week earlier. The workshop was postponed. The reason for waiting is unknown. Discuss one improvement without blaming or inventing motives.

Role A: Review facilitator: ask for the observed sequence and separate it from suspected causes.

Role B: Workstream lead: propose an earlier escalation checkpoint and volunteer an owner.

Possible opening: We know when the conflict was noticed and raised, but we do not yet know why escalation waited.

Success checks

- Describe the sequence without attributing motives.
- Connect the late escalation to the documented scheduling effect.
- Agree an owned improvement and a way to review its usefulness.

Add a complication: A participant calls the delay proof that the team did not care.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Project Management English

Professional audience: project managers, program managers, PMO staff, scrum masters, delivery leads, operations managers, and cross-functional coordinators

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Dialogue 01: Defining the deliverable

Original fictional setting: A sponsor and project manager clarify a vague request.

Professional roles: Project manager / Project sponsor

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

Project manager: When you say a customer portal, which capabilities must be in the first release?

Project sponsor: Order status and document downloads. Payments can wait.

Project manager: Who will accept the deliverable, and against what criteria?

Project sponsor: Operations will confirm that customers can find their orders and approved documents.

Project manager: Let's make those acceptance criteria measurable before we baseline the scope.

Project sponsor: Include our service manager in that discussion.

Project manager: I'll document the exclusions and send the scope statement for review.

Project sponsor: Good. That should also make later change requests easier to evaluate.

Vocabulary in this exchange: scope: Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions. / baseline: A defined starting value or agreed reference used to measure change. / deliverable: A specified item of work to be provided to a customer or project recipient. / acceptance criteria: Specific conditions a deliverable must meet to be accepted.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.
2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.
3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.
4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.
5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.
2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.
3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.
4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.
5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level